MICHAEL CHERNYAKOV · COACHING

FREE COACHING RESOURCE

Say Yes... Slowly

How to say No without saying No, and get your day back.



THE PROBLEM

The real problem isn't No. It's a fast Yes.

You start your day with a plan. Then a message lands: "Can you just do this?" Then another: "Could you quickly look at that?" Someone stops by your desk: "Got a minute?" By ten o'clock the plan is gone. By lunch your day belongs to everyone else. And by evening you wonder: when did I agree to all of this?

Most of us don't overcommit because we can't refuse. We overcommit because we agree too quickly, before we know what we're taking on, how big it is, or why we were asked. A fast Yes feels helpful and makes an awkward moment go away. The cost shows up later, in your evenings and your priorities.

In *The Coaching Habit*, Michael Bungay Stanier shares an idea he learned from Bill "Mr. Simplicity" Jensen: the secret to saying No is to say Yes more slowly. You don't refuse. You don't agree. You get curious first.

THE PRINCIPLE

Stay curious before committing.

Six questions to ask before you say Yes

You don't need all six. Pick the one or two that fit the moment.

1 Why are you asking me?
Are you the right person, or just the first name that came to mind?

2 Who else have you asked?
Find out if you're the backup plan, or if others are already on it.

3 When you say urgent, what do you mean?
"Urgent" can mean tonight, or sometime before Thursday.

4 To what standard, and by when?
A polished board deck and five rough slides are very different jobs.

5 If I could only do part, which part?
Invites prioritising without sounding like a refusal.

6 What should I take off my plate?
You're not saying No. You're making the trade-off visible.

WHAT TO EXPECT

What happens when you ask

Staying curious usually leads to one of four responses. Three of them work in your favour.

1 THE ONE THAT ISN'T USEFUL

"Stop asking. Just do it."

Depending on the person, the culture and the urgency, sometimes you're simply expected to deliver. Even so, you've learned how this environment works.

2 WORKS FOR YOU

They have good answers.

A win. The request was thought through, and you weren't picked just because your name popped up first. Now you can commit with your eyes open.

3 WORKS FOR YOU

They don't know, but will find out.

Also good. It buys you time at a minimum, and quite often the request quietly never comes back.

4 WORKS FOR YOU

A negotiation.

Your questions open a conversation. "Okay, just do the three data slides and push the report to next week." You agree to something smaller, clearer or better prioritised.

Say Yes to the person, No to the task

Saying No feels hard because it feels like you're saying No to someone. A facilitation trick from the book helps: create a **"third point"**. Write the request down on paper, a whiteboard or a shared screen, then point to it.

SAME ANSWER, DIFFERENT LANDING

"I can't take this on right now" lands very differently from "I can't help you."

Good and bad reasons to say Yes

WEAK REASONS

- To end an awkward conversation quickly
- To be liked
- Pure habit
- You already know you won't really do it

STRONG REASONS

- You asked questions and got good answers
- You know what you'll stop doing to make room
- It's meaningful, high-impact work for you
- It is genuinely non-negotiable

YOUR TURN

Your experiment this week

Pick one question. The next time a “quick favour” arrives, ask it before you answer, then notice which response you get.

The question I’ll try

The request I tried it on

Which of the four responses did I get? What happened?

What I’ll do differently next time

Want to go deeper?

Overcommitting, boundaries and getting your time back are things I work on with coaching clients every week.

Book a conversation · chernyakov-coaching.com

Based on ideas from *The Coaching Habit* by Michael Bungay Stanier, who credits Bill Jensen with “saying Yes more slowly.” Paraphrased and adapted for this guide, with additions from my own coaching practice.